Lesson 13

LEADERS AND LEADERSHIP

13.1 Introduction

Leader is a person who rules or guides or inspires others.

The objective of the rural development programme is to develop peoples' participation. Therefore, it is essential to encourage and train village leaders who will develop effective working relationships with the rural people. The well-recognized method of working with the rural people is through these leaders. The leaders may be good or bad; progressive or constructive but they guide village thinking and lead them to action. The formal and informal village groups function through these recognized leaders. There are limitations in working alone by the extension professional. If he relies on individual contact, then he cannot greatly multiply his efforts. If he works through village leaders, then the ideas spread quickly among the group and village.

Some of the concepts of leadership are as follows:

- ✓ Leadership is the process of directing the behavior of others towards the accomplishment of some common objectives.
- ✓ Leadership is influencing people to get things done to a standard and quality above their norm and doing it willingly.
- ✓ Leadership is a process by which a person influences others to accomplish an objective and directs the organization in a way that makes it more cohesive and coherent.

Leaders carry out this process by applying their leadership attributes, such as beliefs, values, ethics, character, knowledge, and skills. Although your position as a manager, supervisor, lead, etc. gives you the authority to accomplish certain tasks and objectives in the organization, this power does not make you a leader, it simply makes you the boss. Leadership differs in that it makes the followers want to achieve high goals, rather than simply bossing people around.

Good leaders are made not born. If you have the desire and will power, you can become an effective leader. Good leaders develop through a never-ending process of self-study, education, training, and experience. This guide will help you through that process.

To inspire our workers into higher levels of teamwork, there are certain things which we must be, know, and, do. These do not come naturally, but are acquired through continual work and study. Good leaders are continually working and studying to improve their leadership skills; they are NOT resting on their laurels.

Bass' theory of leadership states that there are three basic ways to explain how people become leaders. The first two explain the leadership development for a small number of people. These theories are:

- ✓ Some personality traits may lead people naturally into leadership roles. This is the *Trait Theory*.
- ✓ A crisis or important event may cause a person to rise to the occasion, which brings out extraordinary leadership qualities in an ordinary person. This is the *Great Events Theory*.
- ✓ People can choose to become leaders. People can learn leadership skills. This is the *Transformational Leadership Theory*. It is the most widely accepted theory today and the premise on which this guide is based.

13.2 Qualities of a Good Leader

Here are some of the qualities which can make an individual a good leader:

- ✓ A leader should be commendable and exemplary. A good leader should be trustworthy so that people can follow him. He should live his life with honesty and integrity. He should live a life such that nobody can question his character.
- ✓ A good leader is always enthusiastic about the cause of the people. He must have the capability to see what is good or bad for the people in the long run. He approaches a problem in a holistic manner and never believes himself different from his people and subject.
- ✓ A leader believes in discipline. He follows an orderly manner and routine but still he is tolerant. He takes decision keeping emotions and personal matters aside.
- ✓ A leader has excellent logical and analytical skills. He looks each and every aspect of the situation before arriving to any decision and never loses his temper in difficult situations. He should think positively in each and every situation.
- ✓ A leader should always focus towards his goals, what he has envisioned for and promised to his people. He should take each and every decision keeping in mind the people and his subject.
- ✓ A great leader is proactive and committed to excellence. He always maintains high standard and acts as an idol for his followers. His personal and public life both are remarkable and stain-free.

- ✓ A leader inspires his team to achieve target and lead them to success. He brings best out of them in the time of crisis also.

- ✓ A good leader is the one who can give people voice and direction.

✓ A leader should be tolerant of uncertainty and should always remain tranquil, composed and persistent to his goals.

✓ A good leader always keeps a cool head in times of crises and finds solutions to get everybody out of any difficult situation.

13.3 Types of Leader or Leadership Style

Leadership style is the manner and approach of providing direction, implementing plans, and motivating people. This early study has been very influential and established three major leadership styles. The three major styles of leadership are,

- ✓ Authoritarian or autocratic
- ✓ Participative or democratic
- ✓ Delegative or Free Reign

Although good leaders use all **three styles**, with one of them normally dominant, bad leaders tend to stick with one style.

i. Authoritarian (Autocratic)

This style is used when leaders tell their employees what they want done and how they want it accomplished, without getting the advice of their followers. Some of the appropriate conditions to use it are when you have all the information to solve the problem, you are short on time, and your employees are well motivated.

Some people tend to think of this style as a vehicle for yelling, using demeaning language, and leading by threats and abusing their power. This is not the authoritarian style, rather it is an abusive, unprofessional style called **bossing people around**. It has no place in a leader's repertoire.

The authoritarian style should normally only be used on rare occasions. If you have the time and want to gain more commitment and motivation from your employees, then you should use the participative style.

ii. Participative (Democratic)

This style involves the leader including one or more employees in the decision making process (determining what to do and how to do it). However, the leader maintains the final decision

making authority. Using this style is not a sign of weakness; rather it is a sign of strength that your employees will respect.

This is normally used when you have part of the information, and your employees have other parts. Note that a leader is not expected to know everything this is why you employ *knowledgeable* and *skillful* employees. Using this style is of mutual benefit it allows them to become part of the team and allows you to make better decisions.

iii. Delegative or laissez faire (free reign)

In this style, the leader allows the employees to make the decisions. However, the leader is still responsible for the decisions that are made. This is used when employees are able to analyze the situation and determine what needs to be done and how to do it. You cannot do everything! You must set priorities and delegate certain tasks.

This is not a style to use so that you can blame others when things go wrong, rather this is a style to be used when you fully trust and confidence in the people below you. Do not be afraid to use it, however, use it **wisely!**